Infographic · Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography

China's development and why Africa's path is different

CHINA

How geography built a unified, centralised power

Point 1

Agriculture + geographical features

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, an imaginary line from Heihe to the province of Yunan, explains the disparity of China's population and how China developed in the way it did: the fertile east is densely populated and the West is not. Terrain, climate and fertile soil shaped the developed, leading it to the centralised China we see today- the geographical features also lead to the creation of buffer zones, later discussed- and geographical features define the general development of the country.

"This imaginary line is probably the most important geographical feature in this country"

Significance

The most important factor- scales largely and introduced a huge agricultural sector based off climate and fertile land.

Point 2

Borders + buffer zones

China's large geographical expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones in the border regions to protect it from instability and possible threats/The buffers act as a deterrent to invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors to aid development. This is a by-product of the fertile east and the agricultural sector, which funds the method. Some of these regions are run as surveillance states, and some may be unhappy with the centralised China- those who live within the buffer states, due to a lack of interconnectedness. Furthermore, it allows China to focus on economic pursuit rather than investing more into military defence, increasing overall efficiency.

"It wants a buffer zone in the border regions to protect it from instability"

Significance: Political implication: More free money to spend, less political instability, fertile land, layer of protection- the CBD is protected by a large variety of natural buffer zones.

Point 3

Naval exploits + sea navigation

A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders, now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea, displaying naval dominance over a local area. This allows China to divide countries, control trade and trade routes, access an expanse of natural resources, commence fishing on a large scale and open employment in different sectors of the economy.

"A green-water navy patrols its maritime borders"

Significance: Powerful navy also acts as a deterrent to possible threats, as well as acting as a form of employment, and the control of the trade arguably across most of Asia due to its naval ground means that it is much easier to generate income for the country, which can be reinvested and used for development.

Comparison

Most important · China vs Africa

Similarities

Both are large-scale regions, whose development was determined by their natural geography: natural barriers decided where people could settle, trade and be governed. Both have had to live with buffers, whilst aiding China, Africa as a continent is greatly hindered by this, especially with a lack of networking and independence.

Differences

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralised state. Africa's rivers are broken by waterfalls, its coast lacks harbours and its interior is split by desert and jungle, so it stayed fragmented and was later divided again by European borders and general colonialism. China, a country is more centralised and has less divide socially, along with a highly educated, skilled and large workforce allowing it to develop at a faster rate than Africa- not only through geography but other features as well.

Which would be bigger?

Africa is roughly three times China's land area, acting as a continent, which struggles with religious divide and vested interest from many countries, rendering it extremely difficult to develop even infrastructure, exacerbated by the difficulties of terrain for example, the waterfalls constantly breaking rivers.

Why does one develop faster?

China's geography concentrates people, food and power, letting the state plan, build and now project force at sea. Africa's geography disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. One benefits from great unity and overall

interconnectedness whilst the other is caused by divide, because as previously stated the vested interests make it impossible to develop as a continent and it is harder at a larger scale.

AFRICA

How geography and imposed borders held a continent back

Point 1

Natural barriers

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Its great rivers are broken by waterfalls and rapids, so they are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. It has little connectiveness to European and even Asian countries, as well as the fact that the north and south are poorly connected- they basically operate as two separate polarised states. Trade and infrastructure are expensive to build around these barriers, not only due to geographical features but also due to the general social divide caused by perhaps colonialism.

"These are just two in a long list of problems that help explain why Africa isn't as technologically or politically advanced"

Significance: Geography's importance cannot be understated- it is a huge contributor to both political and economic deficiencies.

Point 2

Borders drawn by colonialism + war

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups, for example in Sudan and Somalia. This promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and economic instability. It contrasts with China's centralised, unified core protected by buffer zones and limits the possibilities of agreement and local trade within the continent.

"Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers with which nature endowed them"

Significance: Imposed borders turned natural division into permanent conflict, blocking the stable centralised state which has been developed by China.

Point 3

Population growth

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African. The continent as a whole, to accommodate this massive increase in numbers will need to not only increase agricultural gain to feed

everyone, but heavily develop infrastructure for example housing and disease, as in the future there will be an inevitably huge disparity in wealth- many will live in slums. Furthermore, the population may lead to outbreaks of disease, overcrowding and hinder Africa. Due to religious beliefs, it is near impossible to agree on the promotion of contraception and this may be Africa's most doomed factor. They have the natural resources, they are just divided socially and must unite to resolve their looming problems of debt, infrastructure and overpopulation.

"One in four people will be African"

Significance: Inevitable disparity: many will live in slums, which takes away from a balanced, interconnected development model, which is not sustainable for all people.